CHAPTER 9 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

The Freedmen's Bureau

The first great federal effort to help millions of newly freed people build lives in freedom — and the limits it ran into. 1865–1872.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

The first great federal effort to help millions of newly freed people build lives in freedom — and the limits it ran into. 1865–1872.

How do you measure whether a government program 'succeeded' when it was given an impossible job and too little to do it with?

An Impossible Assignment

1865

When the war ended, nearly four million freedpeople faced freedom with no money, no land, and, often, no way to find lost family. In March 1865 Congress created the Freedmen's Bureau to help — the first federal social-welfare agency in American history.

Its job was staggering: provide food and medical care, set up schools, help negotiate fair labor contracts, reunite families, and legalize marriages — across a hostile, war-wrecked South.

The Bureau's Hardest Job

ALFRED R. WAUD, 1868

In this famous engraving, a Bureau agent stands between an armed white crowd and a Black crowd — keeping the peace. The image captures the Bureau's role: protecting freedpeople in a land that resented them.

"The Freedmen's Bureau" — wood engraving by Alfred R. Waud, Harper's Weekly, 1868, public domain (Library of Congress).

Schools, Contracts, and Reunions

WHAT IT ACHIEVED

The Bureau's accomplishments were real. It issued millions of food rations, built or supported some 4,000 schools (laying the foundation for Black education, including the first HBCUs), and helped tens of thousands reunite with family and formalize marriages.

It also tried to referee the new world of free labor, enforcing contracts so that freedpeople would actually be paid for their work.

The five military districts, 1867 — map, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).

Underfunded and Under Fire

WHAT HELD IT BACK

But the Bureau was overwhelmed. It was always short of money and agents, faced fierce white resistance and violence, and President Johnson vetoed efforts to strengthen it.

Its greatest failure was land. The promise of “forty acres” mostly evaporated when Johnson returned confiscated land to its former Confederate owners. Without land, most freedpeople were pushed back toward working for their former enslavers. By 1872, the Bureau was shut down.

A FREEDMEN'S BUREAU TEACHER

The colored people … are eager to learn. … They will starve themselves, and go without clothes, in order to send their children to school.

Weigh the Record

YOUR TURN

You'll weigh the Bureau's successes against its limits and practice evaluating evidence — reaching a fair verdict on a program given an impossible task.